THE RECORDING AS ARTEFACT OF PLAY

Marshall Heiser

Qld Conservatorium of Music,

Griffith University

ABSTRACT

Zak (2010) states that sound recording provides a means for combining "musical and technological ideas and actions in a multifaceted creative process…whose resulting works expand traditional concepts of musical content, meaning and style (p.321). And yet, George Martin recalls when he first started out in the music business, a record producer's "ultimate aim" was to fashion audio facsimiles of 'live' performances with great earnestness (Badman, 2000: 256). Notwithstanding the practice of linear editing - commonplace ever since magnetic tape replaced direct-to-disc recording (Southall, Vince & Rouse, 2002) - Martin's own post-*Revolver* (1966) output increasingly constituted an illusory fabrication. Mulitrack recording (though long extant by the late sixties) facilitated an additional means of joining together many disparate musical utterances 'as if' they were one (albeit, now in a concurrent manner). Such developments in technology alone however, didn't inspire practitioners to fully exploit the interactive potential of the medium. Instead, a thoroughly *playful* frame of mind informed such fanciful 'productions' as The Beach Boys "Good Vibrations" (1966) and The Beatles' *Sgt. Pepper's Lonely Hearts Club Band* (1967); and in doing so, ushered in a new standards of practice (Miles, 1998; Leaf, 2004).

Similarly, if the proliferation in recent years of low-cost, broadcast quality Digital Audio Workstations (DAWs) is to facilitate anything more than greater convenience for practitioners, a corresponding challenging of certain tacit assumptions must be forthcoming. Brian Eno states: "'As soon as the music is on tape…it ceases to be a purely temporal art, a performance art, and becomes a plastic art.'" (quoted in Sheppard, 2009: 311). The manipulation of sound so well facilitated by DAW technology (which brings multitrack recording, non-linear editing and automated mixing to the masses), potentialises a process of *combinatorial play* (Hadamard, 1945). Such an approach can best be facilitated by a frame of mind where "implications beyond the present moment" are temporarily banished from awareness (Apter, 1991: 14). In this way, the often product-orientated concept of 'performance' can enlarged to include careful scrutiny of the phenomenological flavour of its processes. By reframing contemporary recordings as assemblages of 'artefacts of play,' rather than algorithmic (or by-rote) constructions, it will be argued that future record makers can be encouraged to more fully exploit the creative possibilities that DAW technology engenders.

1. REFERENCES

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